

Game on

Agent goes on hunting for the latest and greatest DX11 GPUs

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Last September, AMD shocked everyone by announcing DX11 parts, slightly before DX11 was available. Seven months down the line, they have a slew of new DX11 parts at all price points and finally, finally NVIDIA has woken up with a DX11 offering of their own. My quest for shopping for a new card began quite unexpectedly. Siddharth, one of our newer team members suddenly decided to assemble a new PC, spurred on no doubt, by taunts from old timers Rossi and Michael to join them online for *Quake 3*, *Warcraft 3* and *Bad Company 2* matches. Siddharth's PC, being the fossil it was, would barely run the former two games, but the latter well beyond its capabilities. Our editor in typical fashion, suddenly decided, that he too wanted a new graphic card, so I was in business.

Eleven doubts

If you are wondering what the fuss about DX11 is about, you can read more about it on page 42 in this issue. Both NVIDIA and AMD will sell you a lot of PR talk about how GPUs are not just for gaming and using one with the relevant application support will result in your GPU doing a lot of CPU-like tasks. For example, video encoding, where an NVIDIA-based CUDA application is shown to be five times faster than a CPU at video encoding. Sure – this is true – and today's high-end GPUs are several times more powerful than the best of CPUs, but they weren't designed with X86 applications in mind and are not going to replace a CPU any time in the near future, irrespective of the hype generated.

Decision making

Siddharth wanted something basic – this was his first GPU and “don't go overboard” was his only prerequisite, other than DX11-compatibility. A wise move, because, a year down the line, you would probably only find DX10 and DX11 titles, meaning DX9 cards would not work with these titles. Up to a year ago, the market was mostly NVIDIA dominated from top to bottom i.e. at all price points. Although NVIDIA still dominates the entry-level market, the mid-range spectrum is a little more competitive since only AMD has newer, DX11 GPUs. The high-end segment is pretty much AMD dominated, although the introduction of the GeForce GTX 480 and GTX 470 might change that.

However, nothing much changes when dealing with shopkeepers as I discovered, and they still try to suggest the cheapest card on hand, to make a sale. Most vendors are so eager to make a sale that they hardly bother suggesting something that is “bang for buck” preferring instead to recommend the cheapest item available. One Lamington Road dealer, who obviously did not remember me, actually offered me a GeForce 6200 for 900 bucks – a Jurassic card that I would not have kept if given free. I even saw a Zebronic GeForce FX5500 – I urge people to skip such ancient chipsets altogether. I also get a lot of mails from people who have AGP slots and want to game. I recommend against this, as AGP cards command a premium since they're end-of-life. It's better to simply upgrade to a PCI Express-based motherboard.

The market is full of cards from XFX, Sparkle, Palit, Sapphire, MSI and

ZOTAC. I did not come across any cards from ASUS, although they are available if one wishes to order through a dealer. EVGA was not available at all – most dealers quoted no stock with the distributor. Palit typically uses innovative coolers on their higher range of cards, but I feel the quality of PCB used by Palit is a little inferior to the likes of ZOTAC, XFX and Sapphire. If you're looking for a graphic card to use in an HTPC I suggest looking for something under Rs. 2,500 – there's no sense spending more if you are not going to be gaming and even an entry-level graphic card will easily run 1080p content. A GeForce 8400GS chipset will suffice, I recommend Palit or MSI, both of which should be available for around Rs. 1,800. Siddharth wanted something to game on as well. AMDs Radeon HD 4670 and HD 5670 were available, for Rs. 5,000 and Rs. 5,600 respectively – the latter is a DX11 card. NVIDIA's GT 240 is also available – a really fast card, for 5,500 bucks. For AMD, I saw options from Sapphire, PowerColor and Palit whereas the NVIDIA options were Palit, XFX and MSI. He opted for the Sapphire HD 5670 and I was able to haggle and get him the card for a hundred bucks less.

In the high-end spectrum, I could find no DX11 NVIDIA cards in the market. The GeForce GTX 295 is the sole campaigner along with the slower GTX 285. AMDs Radeon HD 5870 and HD 5850 which are their higher end DX11 offerings were available and PowerColor was priced a little below the Sapphire cards. In the end, I chose a HD 5850 for our editor and after a quick phone call, he agreed. The price difference between Sapphire and PowerColor was close to 600 bucks and I managed to haggle with the dealer for a better price. After 15 minutes of bargaining, I picked up the PowerColor HD 5850 for Rs. 16,600 – this card will run all games on resolutions up to 1920 x 1200 – and is a good choice for gamers looking at something future proof but not too expensive, for the next series of GPUs are due by the end of this year. **d**